



S.G. Ganesh

Abort, Retry, Fail?

Exception handling is tricky to get right. In this column, I present some guidelines for writing good exception handling code, by giving real-world (counter) examples.

Guideline 1: Write descriptive error messages.

Guideline 2: Check for syntax errors before shipping! If your application is written in an interpreted language or a scripting language, your users can end up getting syntax errors if you don't test it well.



Microsoft VBScript runtime error '800a01a8'

Object required: 'pool'

/Trading/Equity/Trading.asp, line 76

Guideline 3: Write helpful error messages. In the following example, what exactly is the difference between 'Abort' and 'Fail'? Also, it is better to specify what needs to be done to recover from the situation—for example, 'Insert disk' instead of 'Retry'.

```
C:\>DIR A:
```

```
Not ready reading drive A
Abort, Retry, Fail?_
```

Guideline 4: Don't contradict yourself. When throwing an error back to the user, the description should support why an exception happened, not contradict it.



Guideline 5: Don't try humour. If yours is a 'critical' application, your user will not laugh when an exceptional situation occurs!

500 Internal Server Error

Sorry, something went wrong.

A team of highly trained monkeys has been dispatched to deal with this situation.

If you see them, show them this information:

```
6L83CUN5lw3d_g0a27fwjy8tVq8N2401t_uidd71lxK5m8F2ANLck_sabib
9T3wVDF-wagvheBCroSLiY8h1x1N8aGw9In8N1Y5J0418v1_LN8d01ZdXFL3
```



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